

was already a veteran of the professional world, ploughing a lonely furrow as the first Indian woman on the Ladies Professional Golf Association (LPGA) Tour — the top-drawer circuit in golf — way back in 1997. On Sunday, golf lovers' hopes rested on a 21-year-old in her first full season on the LET.

Hitaashee had started well on the final day, a couple of birdies and a three-shot lead keeping her in the game through the first four holes. But the final-day jitters caught up with the youngster. Three bogeys in a row were followed by a horrendous double bogey on the par-5 eighth hole. Play got held up for almost 20 minutes as players and referees debated whether her tee shot had landed out of bounds before rolling into the water or within the course line. She eventually had to trudge back to the start for her third shot and never recovered.

England's Alice Hewson, part of the leader group with Hitaashee and Pranavi Urs (**below**), risked little and stayed steady with a couple of birdies, parring the rest to cruise ahead, closing in on the trophy even as her closest competitor, Shannon Tan, sat in the clubhouse waiting for the formalities to be completed before flying home as the runner-up for the second year running.

Instead, the 21-year-old Singaporean, who started the final round seven shots off the lead, saw Hewson first hit her tee shot into the water and then miss an easy putt for a double bogey on the very last hole, to be handed the title in the most dramatic way possible.

For the home fans, however, it was the performance of the Indian golfers that held promise. Four Indians in the top 10 was unimaginable even a few years ago, despite Aditi Ashok's victory way back in 2016 as an 18-year-old. Aditi, now a regular on the LPGA — the only Indian on the tour — even came close to a historic Olympic medal in Tokyo before a heartbreaking fourth-place finish.

Consider this: when the first-ever professional tour was launched in October 2006, it included five legs for a prize purse of ₹6 lakh with five



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players. This year, the Women's Professional Golf Tour of India has 13 legs with 54 players vying for a total prize money of ₹229 lakh. Sitting pretty on top of the India Order of Merit is the experienced Vani Kapoor, with four wins and earnings exceeding ₹16 lakh. Vani, who has never missed a cut in her 13 appearances in the Indian Open, admitted it has been a learning curve. "It makes me feel really proud of myself that I'm still here, still giving them a fight. Obviously, I'm doing something right and that's really good. When I started there were fewer girls and the organisation and all the golfing bodies were also growing with us — we were gaining experience together," she said.

She agreed that perceptions played a big role and needed to change. "There's this misconception that golf is an elite sport; the government definitely thinks so. That's why they don't provide that much financial aid to golfers. But

most people who are playing golf don't come from rich backgrounds. Today, if I don't have a few sponsors, I cannot be playing golf. One cannot reach one's true potential because we have so many constraints. Also, I'm a firm believer that every corporate house should support a sport. And then you see the results. You need support not just after you become a star, but before," she shrugged.

Kavita, however, knows it's a long road ahead.

"In the early days, we got no support from the government at all. I was turned down brutally by the sports minister and the tourism minister. We still barely do. If it were not for the corporate sector, it would have been very tough. But I want an Indian girl to win — maybe in the Olympics, maybe here. There's no lack of talent in our country. It's about discipline, consistency, and hard work. And the hunger has to be there. But I really hope we get an Olympic medallist," she declared.



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